Mayoral Partisanship and its Effect on Housing Cost

Patrick Campbell

QSS 82 One Quarter Research Project · Quantitative Social Science · Dartmouth College

Research Question

Does the partisan affiliation of city mayors influence future housing price growth in U.S. cities?

- Understanding whether political leadership affects housing outcomes can help clarify the role of local politics in housing market performance.
- Existing research often focuses on macroeconomic drivers of housing markets. This study contributes by examining the association of mayoral partisanship with housing price growth. [2][1]
- Using a panel dataset of U.S. cities, this study analyzes the relationship between mayoral partisanship and forward-looking housing price growth.

Main Finding: Mayoral party affiliation alone does not show a strong or consistent relationship with future housing price growth.

Data

- Source: Housing data from Zillow; mayoral partisanship from municipal election records. Data was filtered to cities that had a change in mayoral party at least one from the years 2005–2019.
- Unit of analysis: City-year
- Sample: *N* = 1,178; across multiple U.S. cities
- Key variables:
  - Outcome: Housing price growth, measured as forward-looking percent change in median home value.
  - Treatment: Mayoral partisanship, measured as an indicator variable; Republican(1) Democrat(0).
  - Controls: City and Year

Table 1. Summary Statistics

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Pctl(25)	Median	Pctl(75)	Max
Median Home Value	1,178	287,548.70	193,937.30	63,900	156,675	226,300	350,300	1,163,900
Republican	1,178	0.47	0.50	0	0	0	1	1
1 year	1,104	2.54	12.82	−40.69	−3.16	2.75	8.87	83.74
2 years	1,030	4.33	17.09	−52.60	−5.87	4.09	14.79	74.21
3 years	956	5.66	20.87	−55.02	−6.06	4.94	19.59	93.02
4 years	882	7.68	26.38	−59.14	−9.64	6.55	26.33	94.21
5 years	808	9.82	31.10	−61.14	−11.12	6.56	32.20	110.16

Main Findings

- Mayoral partisanship does not show a strong or consistent relationship with future housing price growth across U.S. cities.
- Across multiple time horizons (1–5 years), the estimated effects of Republican mayors on housing price growth are small and statistically insignificant after controlling for city and year fixed effects.

Methodology

Hypothesis:

Cities with Republican mayors experience more housing price growth compared to cities with Democratic mayors.

Linear Regression:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta D_{it} + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{it} represents housing price growth in city i at time t, D_{it} indicates mayoral partisanship (Republican mayor), μ_i are city fixed effects, and λ_t are year fixed effects.

Results

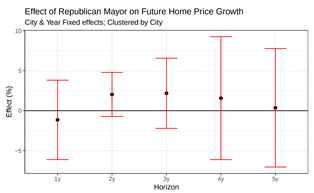


Figure 1. Overall effect of Republican mayors on future housing price growth.

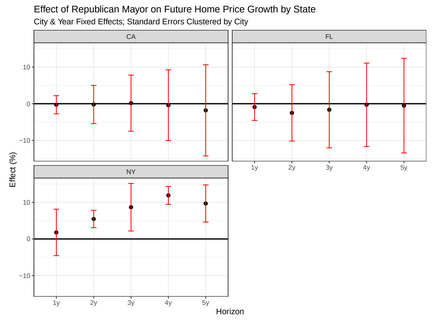


Figure 2. Effect of Republican mayors by state (CA, NY, FL).

Results (cont'd)

Table 2. Regression: Effect of Mayoral Partisanship on Future Housing Price Growth

	Dependent variable:				
	1-year	2-year	3-year	4-year	5-year
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Republican mayor	−1.149	2.028	2.173	1.568	0.361
	(2.533)	(1.408)	(2.238)	(3.923)	(3.778)
City FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
SEs	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city
Observations	1,104	1,030	956	882	808
R^2	0.197	0.366	0.507	0.506	0.517
Adjusted R^2	0.127	0.307	0.457	0.452	0.458
Note:	Outcomes are forward-looking percent changes in median home value. Standard errors clustered by city.				

Discussions & Interpretations

- The results provide limited evidence that mayoral partisanship has a consistent effect on future housing price growth. Across most time horizons, the estimated effects are small and statistically insignificant.
- Housing prices are influenced by many structural factors such as regional economic conditions, housing supply constraints, and state-level policy environments.
- This project highlights the limited explanatory power of mayoral party affiliation alone in predicting housing market outcomes. Future research could incorporate broader political factors such as state-level partisanship or interactions between executive and legislative political control.

References

[1] **Ferreira, Fernando, and Joseph Gyourko.** 2026. "Does Political Partisanship Affect Housing Supply? Evidence From US Cities." *Journal of Urban Economics* 152, p. 103842. [Link]

[2] **Gerber, Elisabeth R., and Daniel J. Hopkins.** 2011. "When Mayors Matter: Estimating the Impact of Mayoral Partisanship on City Policy." *American Journal of Political Science* 55 (2): 326–339. [Link]